

PRASHANT PANJIAR

▲ ANTI-MANDAL AGITATION *(1990)*

ISSUE: Opposition to the V.P. Singh government's decision to implement the Mandal Commission recommendation of 27 per cent reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBC) in central government jobs

YOUTH'S ROLE: Predominantly forward-caste students led strikes and demonstrations, with Delhi University and other campuses becoming major centres of protest. The backlash contributed to the fall of the Janata Dal-led government in November 1990. It also led to OBC mobilisation, paving the way for the rise of leaders such as Lalu Prasad Yadav, Nitish Kumar and Mulayam Singh Yadav.

▼ INDIA AGAINST CORRUPTION *(2011)*

ISSUE: Demand for a strong, independent Lokpal to investigate political corruption amid a string of alleged scams during the UPA rule

YOUTH'S ROLE: Students and young professionals transformed **Anna Hazare**'s campaign into a nationwide movement, using volunteer networks. It pushed Parliament to enact the Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act in 2013 and spawned a new political force: Arvind Kejriwal's Aam Aadmi Party.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

"What they think about the CJP"



"Dipke is nowhere near being a JP, Anna or Kejriwal. CJP's biggest flaw is it doesn't have a Hazare-like figure to rally around. It recognised this deficit when it brought in Sonam Wangchuk"

— YASHWANT DESHMUKH

Psephologist & Co-founder, CVoter



"A risk for the CJP is bureaucratisation: a spontaneous movement becoming so structured that it loses the energy that created it. It must remain lean enough to exert political pressure"

— TANVIR AEIJAZ

Political scientist, Ramjas College, Delhi University

to go in that respect. Veteran socialist and former AAP Maharashtra chief Ranga Rachure says those around the CJP may be "simmering in anger against the system", but lack ideological clarity and a ground organisation capable of holding on to the constituency they have mobilised.

There is an opposite danger as well: too much organisation. Tanvir Aeijaz, political scientist at Delhi University's Ramjas College, warns of "bureaucratisation"—the process by which a spontaneous movement becomes so structured that it loses the very energy that created it. The CJP's immediate test, therefore, may not be whether it can defeat the BJP at the BJP's organisational game. It is whether it can invent a 21st-century movement structure—lean enough to retain digital spontaneity, deep enough to sustain campaigns on the ground and coherent enough to exert political pressure without being swallowed by conventional politics.

Who is the Face of the CJP?

Almost every transformative Indian movement eventually acquired a face. If JP supplied the moral force protesting students in Bihar, V.P. Singh personified Mandal politically and Anna Hazare became the icon of IAC before Kejriwal converted part of its energy into electoral politics. The CJP has the 30-year-old Dipke, an unlikely but not entirely accidental face of the revolt. Born into a middle-class Buddhist Dalit